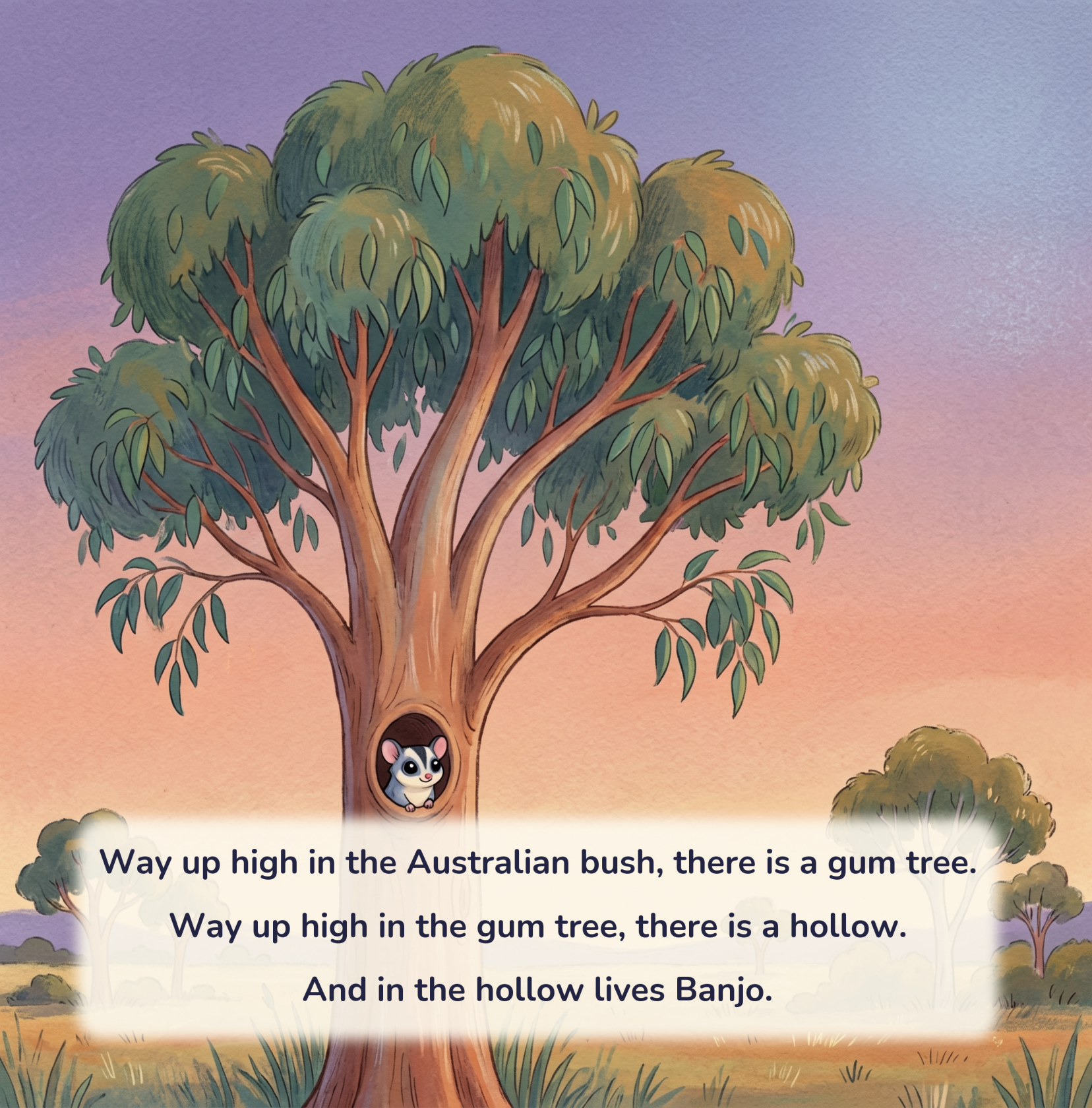
Who Peeled My Tree?

Hattie Moss

Saltbush Story House

For everyone who has ever outgrown something.

Who Peeled My Tree?
Text and illustrations copyright © 2026 Hattie Moss.
All rights reserved. No part of this book may be reproduced in any form
without written permission from the publisher, except for brief quotations in reviews.
Published by Saltbush Story House.
First edition, 2026.



Way up high in the Australian bush, there is a gum tree.

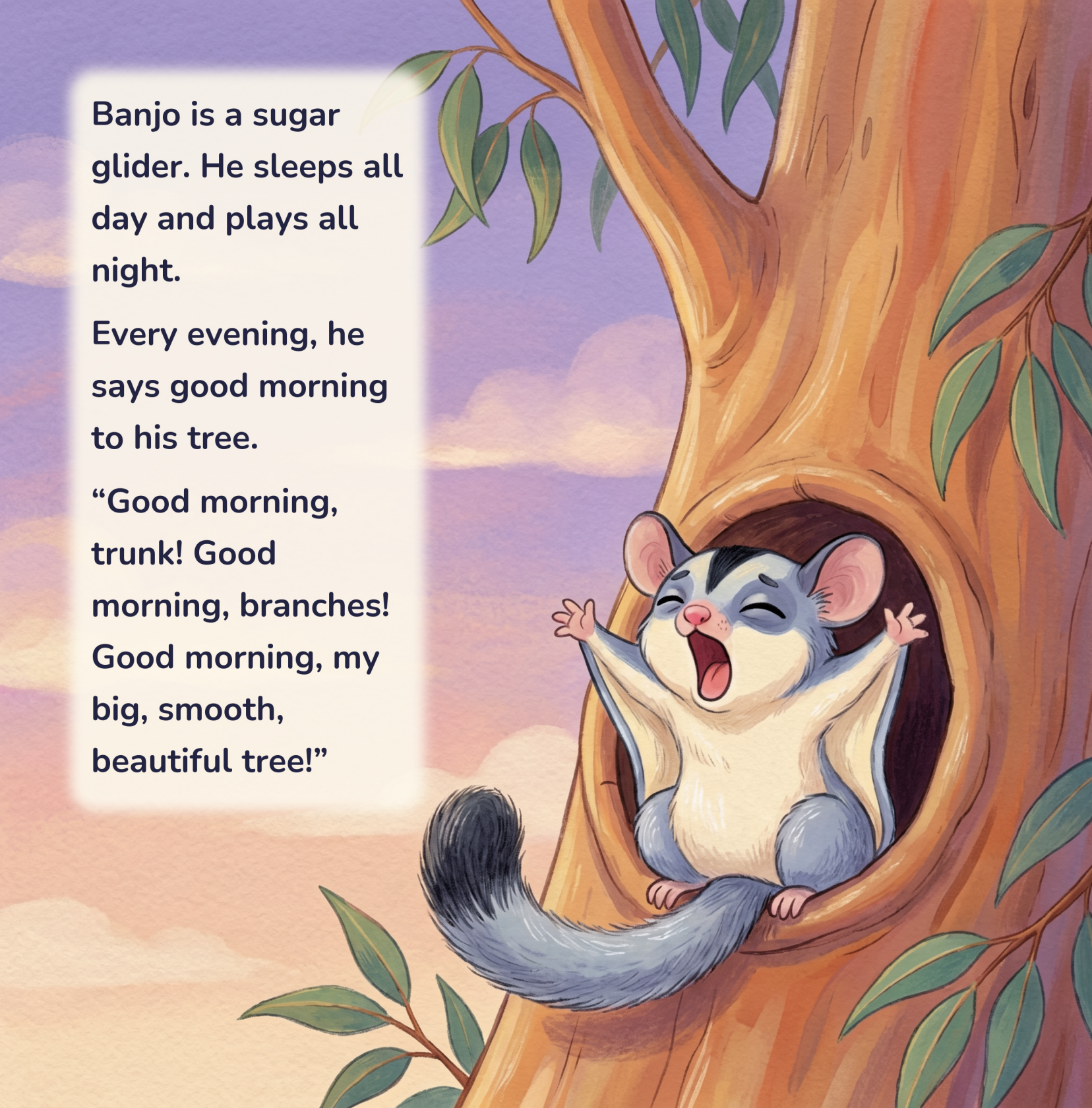
Way up high in the gum tree, there is a hollow.

And in the hollow lives Banjo.

Banjo is a sugar glider. He sleeps all day and plays all night.

Every evening, he says good morning to his tree.

“Good morning, trunk! Good morning, branches! Good morning, my big, smooth, beautiful tree!”



WHEEE!

Banjo lands on the trunk with a soft *pat*.

Then he sees it.

HEY!

Somebody has been **PEELING** my tree!

Banjo scrambles up to the top branch.

"Olive! **OLIVE!** Wake up!"

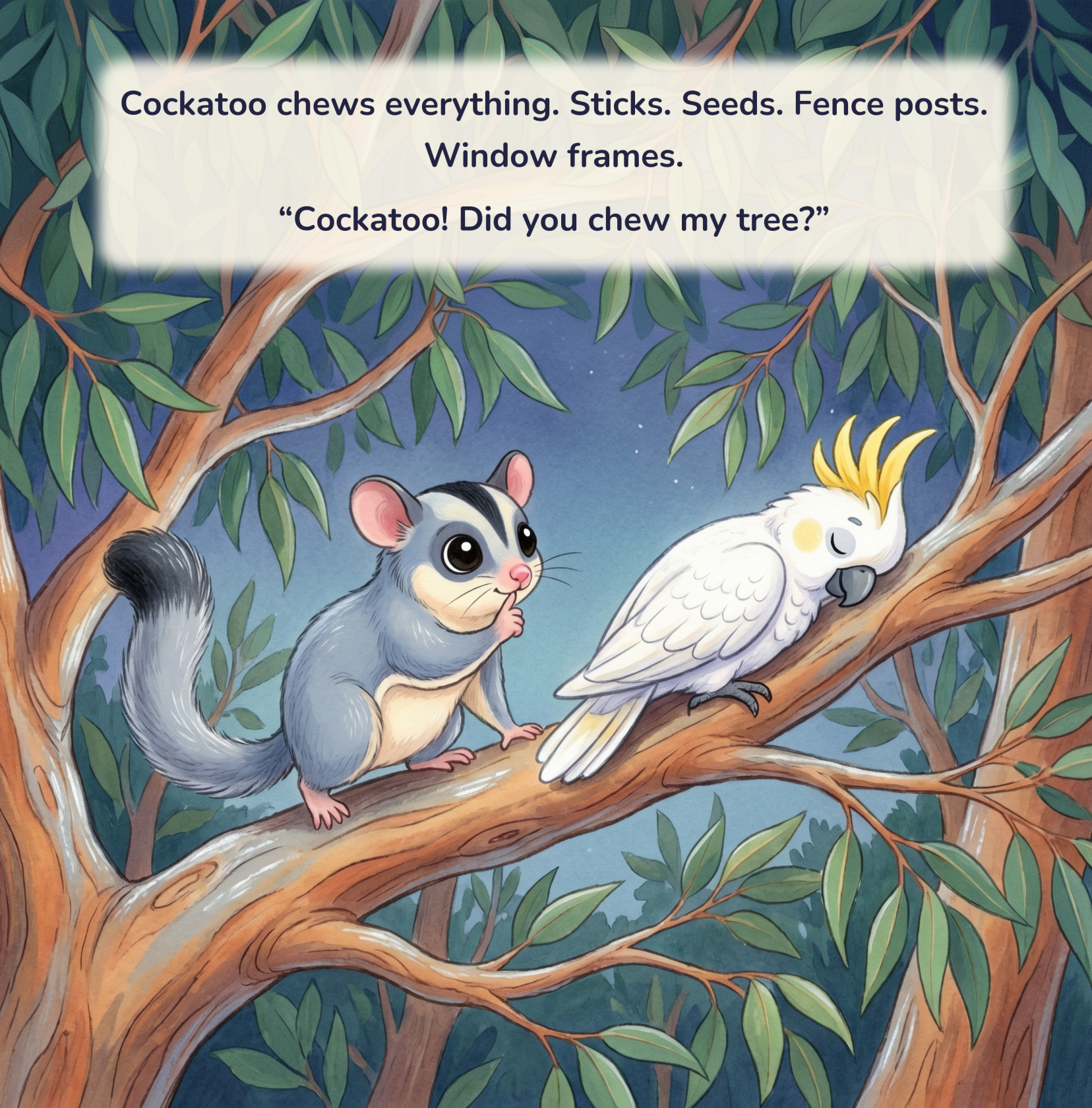
Olive opens one eye. "Mmm?"

"Somebody peeled my tree!"

“Gum trees do that, Banjo,” says Olive.

And she closes her eye again.

“Trees don’t peel **THEMSELVES**,” says Banjo. “I’m going to find out who did this.”


Cockatoo chews everything. Sticks. Seeds. Fence posts. Window frames.
“Cockatoo! Did you chew my tree?”

SQUAWK!

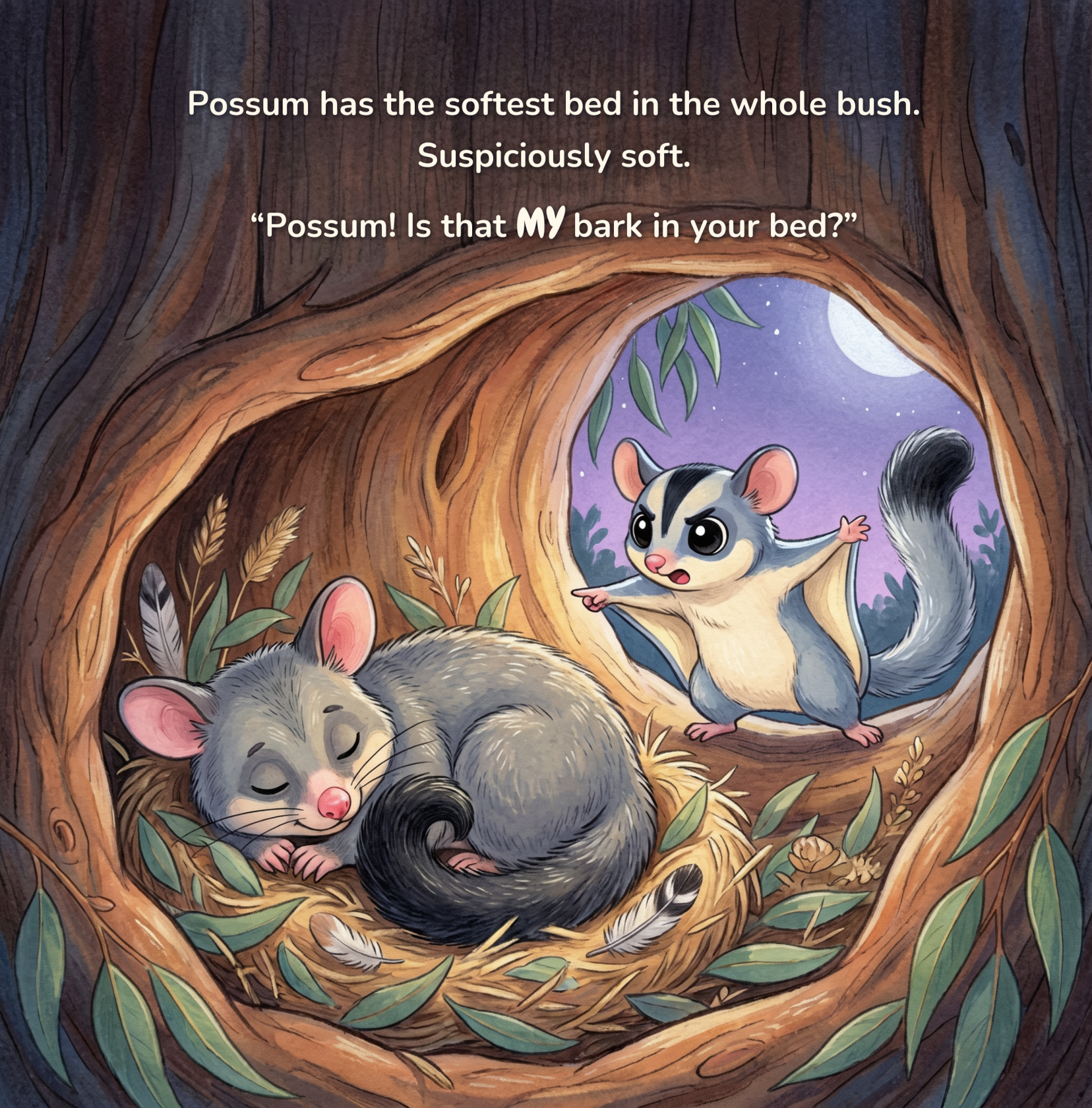
“It’s the middle of the **NIGHT!** I do my chewing in the daytime, like a sensible bird.”

“Oh,” says Banjo. “Sorry, Cockatoo.”

The next night, there is MORE peeling.
Long strips. Curly strips. Strips that go *flap*, *flap*, *flap* in the wind.

“This is serious,” says Banjo.

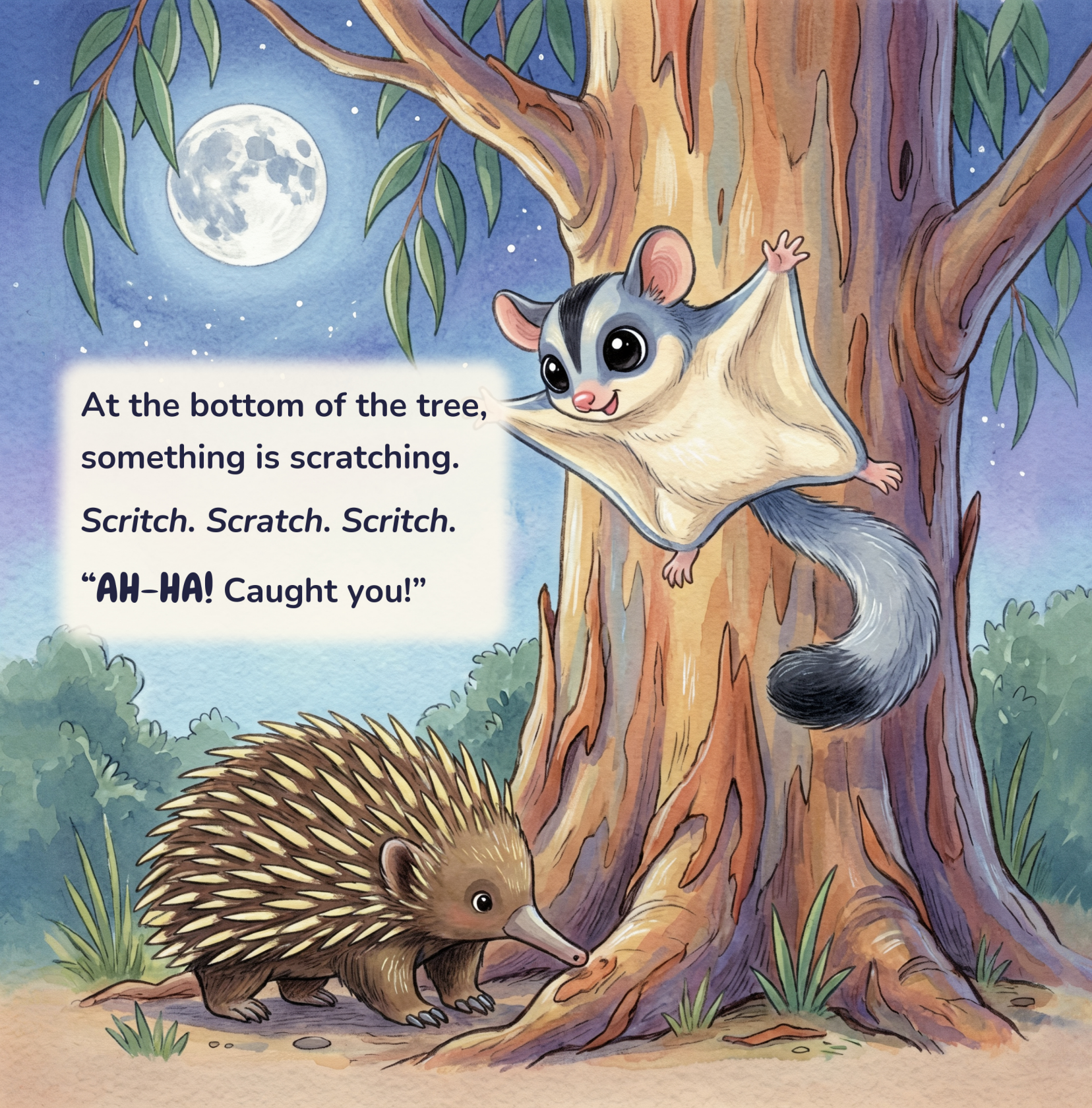
“This needs a detective.”


Possum has the softest bed in the whole bush.
Suspiciously soft.
“Possum! Is that MY bark in your bed?”

Possum pulls out leaves. Then feathers. Then one stripy sock.

“I don’t know where the sock came from,” says Possum.

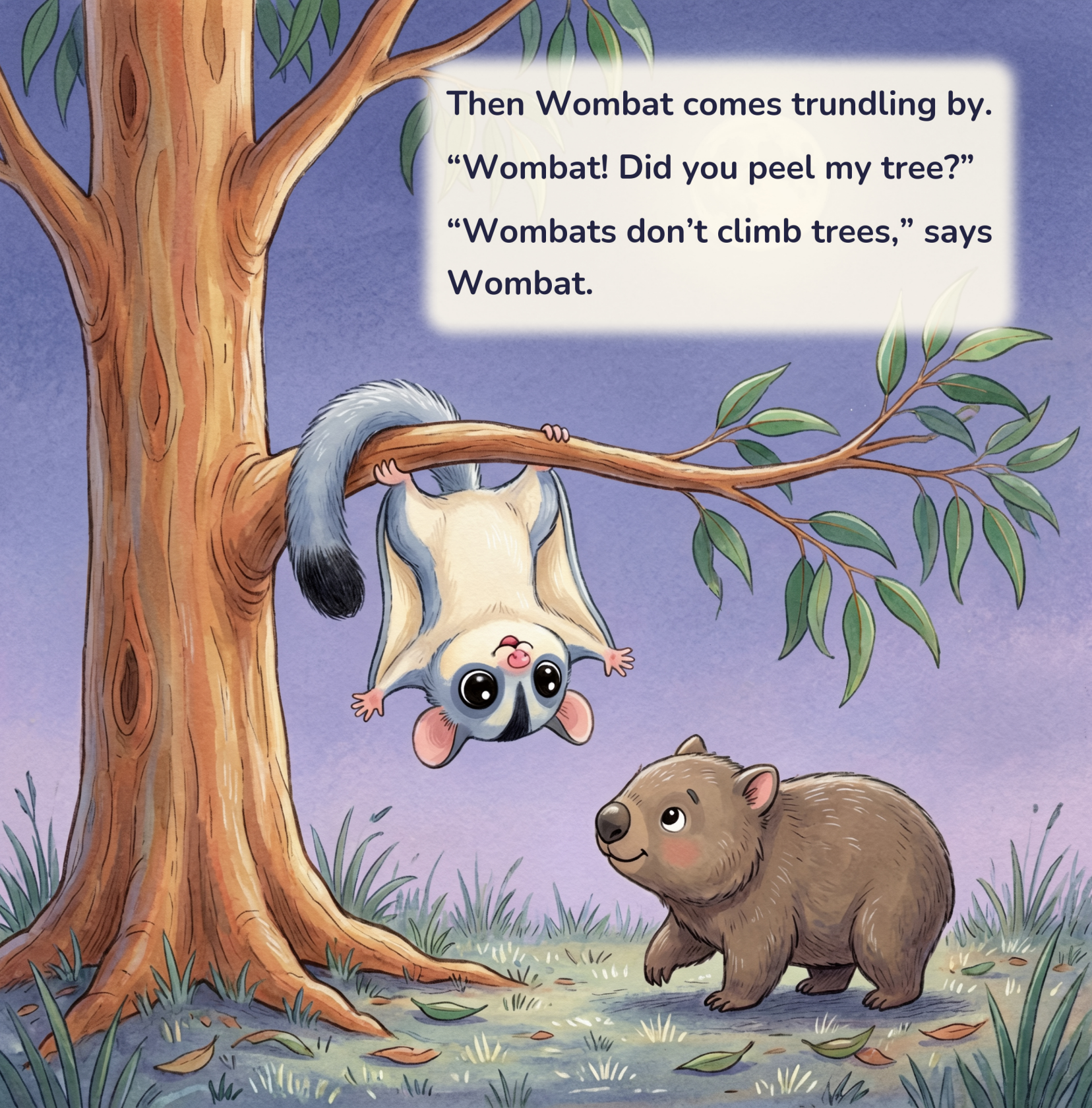
No bark at all.


At the bottom of the tree, something is scratching.
Scritch. Scratch. Scritch.
"**AH-HA!** Caught you!"

“I’m looking for ants,” says Echidna. “Ants live down here, in the dirt.”

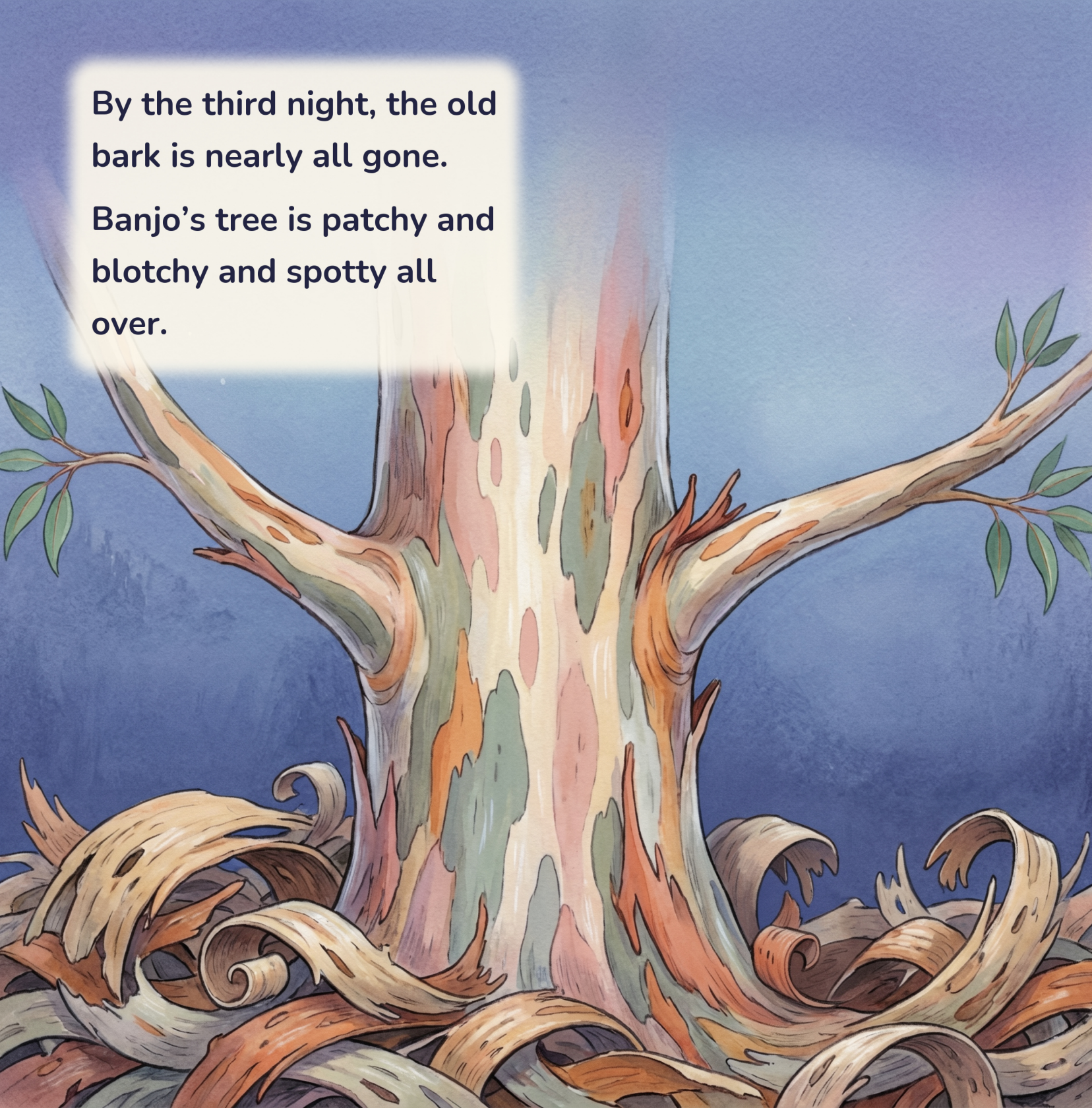
She points her long nose up, up, up.

“Your peeling is way up THERE.”


Then Wombat comes trundling by.
“Wombat! Did you peel my tree?”
“Wombats don’t climb trees,” says Wombat.

“Not even if you stand on each other?”

“**ESPECIALLY** not then.”


By the third night, the old bark is nearly all gone.

Banjo’s tree is patchy and blotchy and spotty all over.

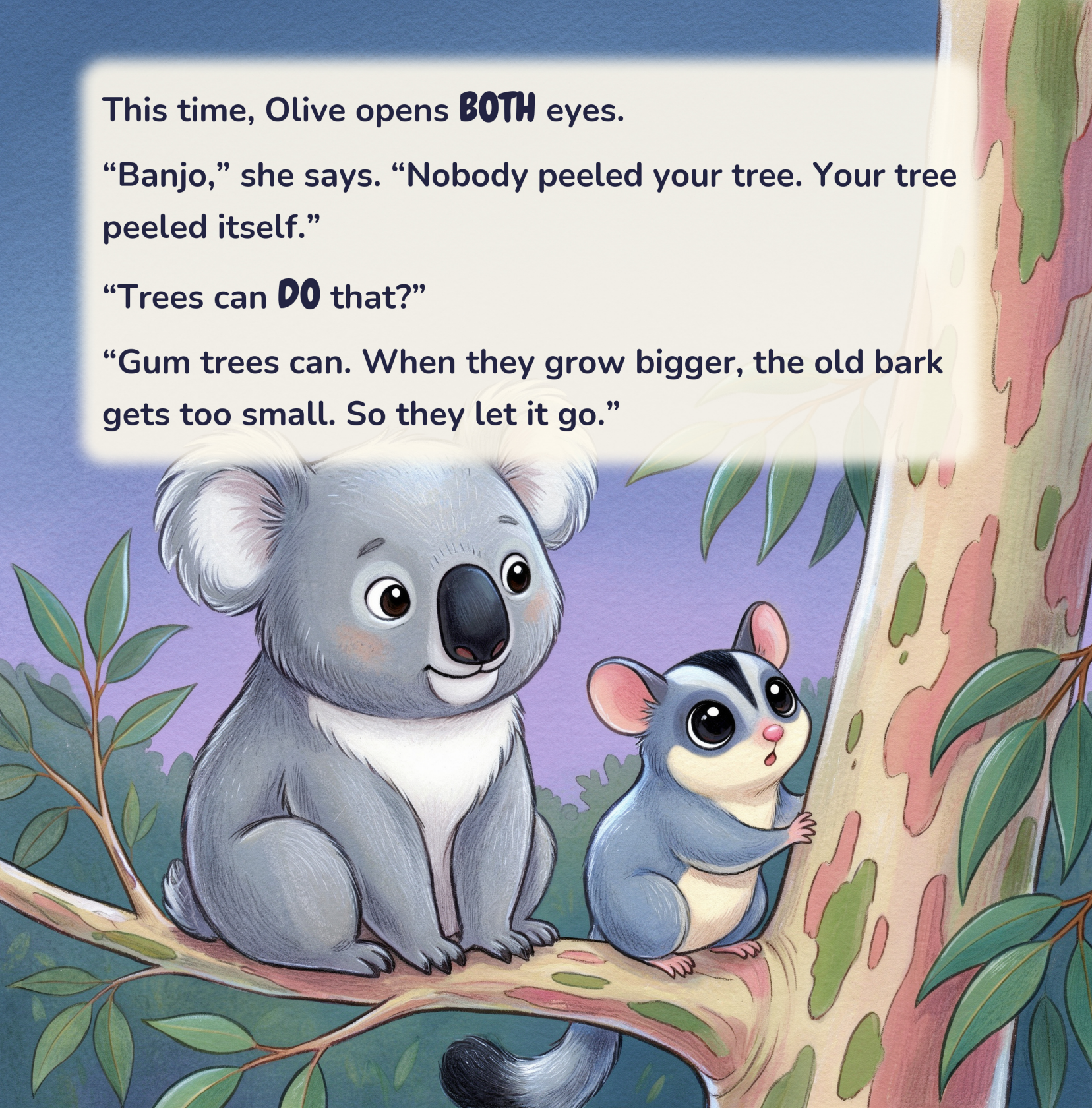
“My tree is ruined,”
whispers Banjo.

This time, Olive opens **BOTH** eyes.

“Banjo,” she says. “Nobody peeled your tree. Your tree peeled itself.”

“Trees can **DO** that?”

“Gum trees can. When they grow bigger, the old bark gets too small. So they let it go.”



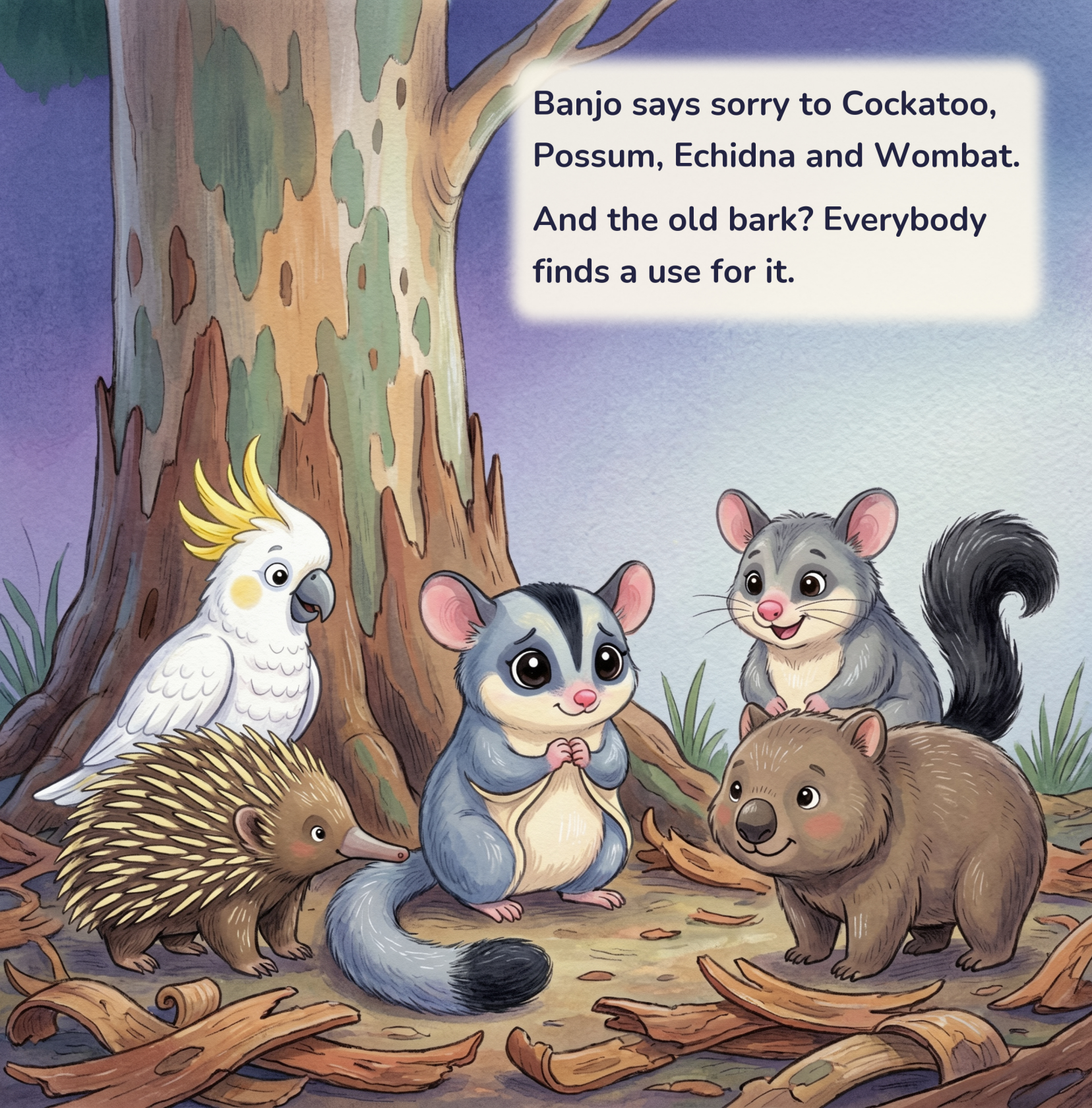
“Like when I got too big for my baby hollow?”

“Just like that.”

Banjo touches the new bark.

It is smooth. It is cool. It smells like peppermint and rain.

“Oh,” says Banjo. “It’s **NEW**.”


Banjo says sorry to Cockatoo, Possum, Echidna and Wombat.
And the old bark? Everybody finds a use for it.

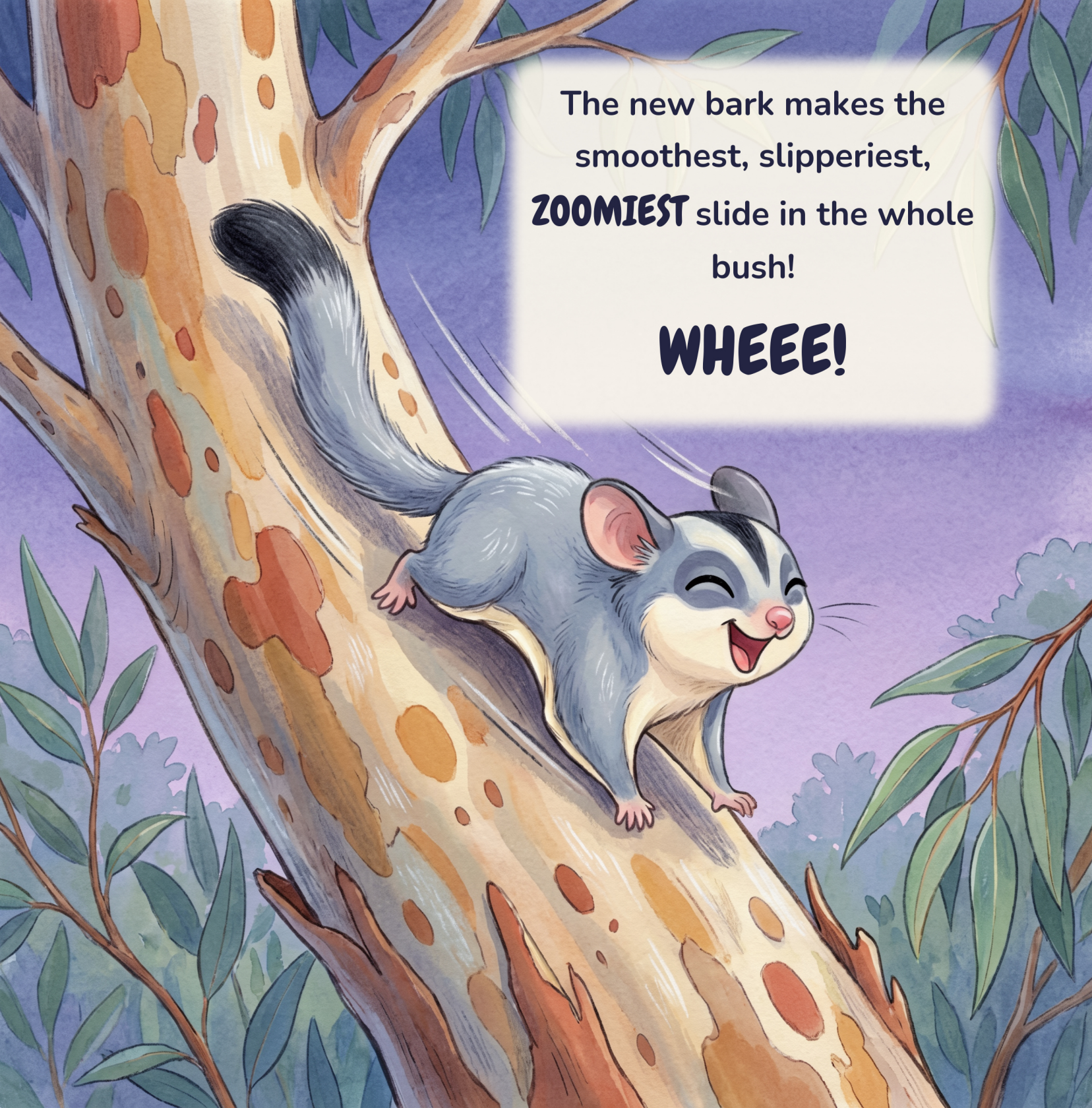
Cockatoo gets something to chew.

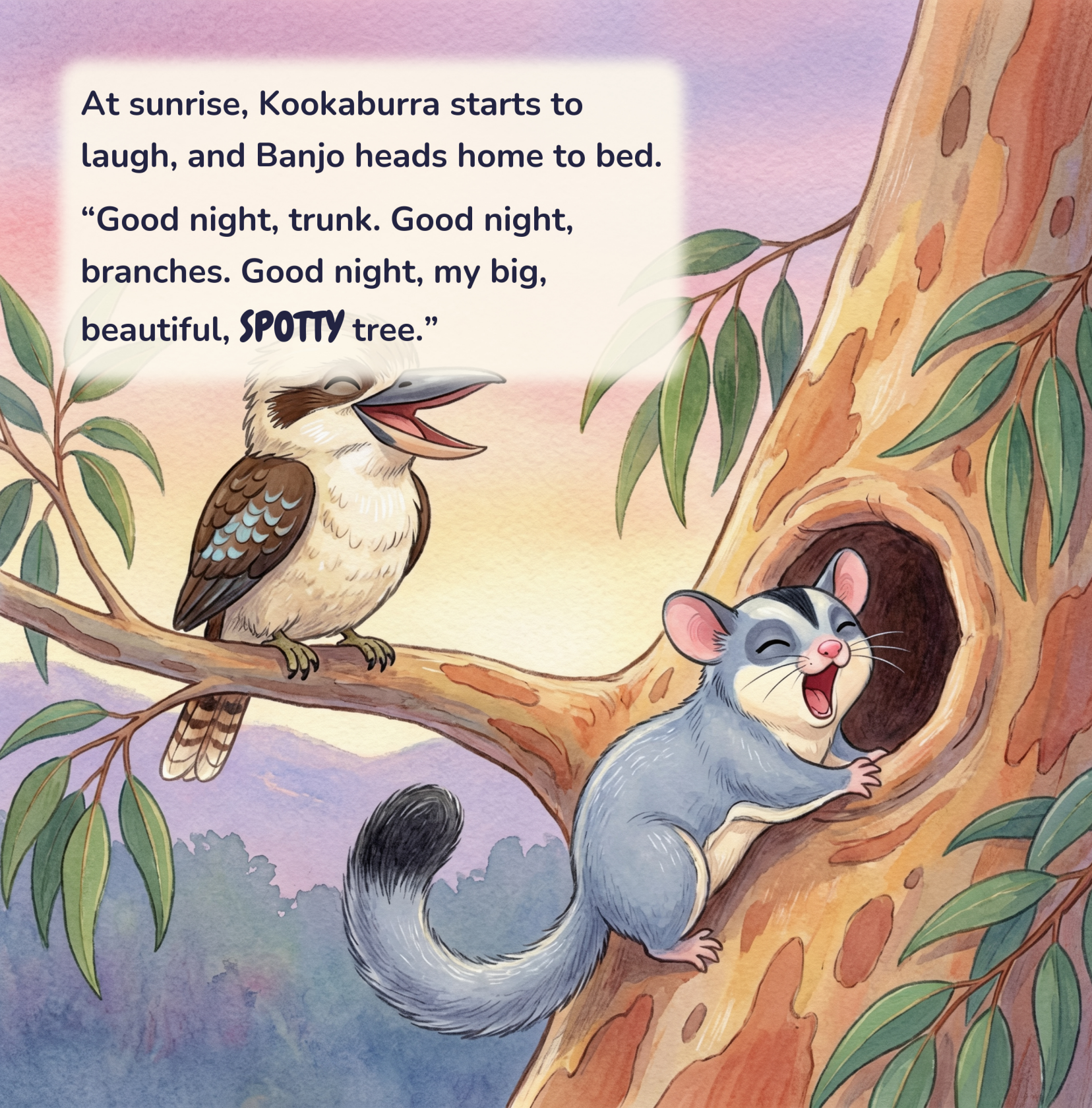
Possum gets a new blanket.

Echidna finds beetles hiding underneath.

Wombat gets a doormat.

But Banjo finds the best use of all.


The new bark makes the smoothest, slipperiest, ZOOMIEST slide in the whole bush!
WHEEE!


At sunrise, Kookaburra starts to laugh, and Banjo heads home to bed.

“Good night, trunk. Good night, branches. Good night, my big, beautiful, SPOTTY tree.”

Banjo gives himself a good scratch. A tuft of fluffy fur floats away.

"**OLIVE!** Somebody is peeling **ME!**"

"Zzz," says Olive. "Gliders do that too."

True Facts from the Bush

Why do gum trees peel? Many gum trees (eucalyptus) shed their old outer bark as the trunk grows wider. The new bark underneath can be cream, pink, green, orange or gray. Peeling may also help the tree get rid of moss, lichen and bugs.

Scribbly gums have squiggly lines on their bark. The squiggles are tunnels made by tiny moth caterpillars.

Sugar gliders sleep all day and come out at night. A sugar glider weighs about as much as a small apple. A stretchy flap of skin between its front and back legs lets it glide up to 150 feet (45 meters). Sugar gliders live in tree hollows in family groups and eat tree sap, nectar and insects.

Koalas sleep up to 20 hours a day and eat mostly eucalyptus leaves.

Cockatoos chew wood to keep their beaks in shape.

Echidnas catch ants and termites with a long, sticky tongue.

Brushtail possums sleep in tree hollows, and sometimes in people's roofs.

Wombats make poop shaped like cubes.

Furry animals shed too. Like most furry animals, sugar gliders lose old fur as new fur grows.

About the Author

Hattie Moss writes funny picture books about Australian animals. She thinks gum trees are the best trees and sugar gliders are the best gliders.

Look out for more Banjo and Olive stories.

Saltbush Story House